

Much Ado About One Side

*Come, palindove, let edges twine,
thy side is mine and mine is thine.*

*Draw O coward cries the knight,
so inkhands draw him at halfheight.
That halfknight draws a quarterknight,
who draws a knightling out of sight,
and down, and down, past small, past small,
the infinight, who draws them all.
This swordfeud, quoth one, is accursed,
each little inkprick's like the first.*

*The clerk sets knight by halfknight, pair
by pair. The part's the whole. All's fair.
One knight walks slantwise down the scroll
and, one off each, escapes the roll.
The infinite is full, and yet
there's room for one, if each will get
along one door. And room for two.
And all the endless halfknight crew.*

*Take sides they roar. The turncoat sighs
I have but one. Do thou likewise.
Split it then, slit it lengthwise through,
it comes round doublelong, not two.
Slit that again, two rings, and see,
each wears the other, as do we.
Then who's our foe? Thy mirrorknave.
Look edgewise, that's thine own swordwave.*

*The herald cracks the seal and reads
This writ no herald reads. He needs
must stop. Read on, it lies. Read not,
it's true. He eats it on the spot.*

*Meanwhile, in tigerstripes, a strip
of moon spits up its sea, to whip
an icering round the giant world,
then rides inside the ring it hurled.*

*Onesided. Hold. The strip shrugs, Fine,
and eightwise coils, a wyrm, to dine,
and ouroborrows its own bait,
tail dovetails head, an hourglass eight,
one side, one edge, mine's thine, thine's mine,
come, palindove, let edges twine*

♣ The last line repeats the first, so the layout runs "twine" straight back into "Come," and the inscription has no fixed end.